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Democracy Dies in Darkness

SUNDAY, MARCH 22, 2026 • \$6

Trump threatens to send ICE to airports

As TSA shortages drive airport delays, standoff over funding escalates

BY EMILY DAVIES

President Donald Trump on Saturday threatened to send U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement agents to airports unless congressional Democrats agree to a GOP-backed funding deal, escalating a standoff that has already slowed security lines at airports nationwide.

In a post to Truth Social, Trump said the ICE agents would “do Security like no one has ever seen before, including the immediate arrest of all Illegal Immigrants who have come into our Country, with heavy emphasis on those from Somalia.”

Deploying agents to checkpoints nationwide would mark an unprecedented expansion of immigration enforcement even as Democrats push for tighter limits on how those agents operate, citing concerns the administration has fast-tracked training to expand ICE ranks.

“This is again an example, it seems to me, of the president seeking to utilize ICE in a way that achieves political goals, almost as a punishment,” said John Sandweg, a former acting director at ICE during the Obama administration. “The operations, to me, don’t seem to be designed to focus on public safety.”

Democrats have refused to fund certain agencies within the Department of Homeland Security — which includes ICE and U.S. Customs and Border Protection —

SEE ICE ON A5

K-pop stars BTS thrill Seoul with comeback

Reunion concert marks completion of members’ mandatory military duties

BY MICHELLE YE HEE LEE

SEOUL — BTS is back, and the K-pop boy band’s fans have taken over the city.

Seoul’s landmarks were lit red, the signature color of the band’s new album. Restaurants and shops decorated their storefronts purple, the color associated with its fandom. Coffee shops and cocktail bars emblazoned their drinks with the logo of the band’s new album. Fans cheered as a drone show displaying the seven band members’ faces lit up the sky over the Han River.

The band reunited on Saturday for a free concert for the first time in nearly four years, at an outdoor event that drew fans from around the world. The K-pop sensation went on hiatus while its members joined the South Korean military for their mandatory service and pursued solo careers.

The event was expected to be so huge that the national government raised its terrorism level alert near the venue. The city of Seoul dispatched thousands of law enforcement officers to the concert area. In the end, the event drew about 42,000 attendees, according to organizers.

SEE CONCERT ON A12



ALEX KENT/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Quite a sight at the museum

BY MICHAEL E. RUANE

They arrived in D.C. after being carried cross-country on a flatbed tractor-trailer, clearing tunnels with inches to spare and turning heads all the way: two massive statues of American bison, each constructed of more than a ton of bronze and bound for the National Mall.

Aided by floodlights, a construction crane lifted them from the truck Thursday and placed them on granite plinths at the entrance of the Smithsonian’s National Museum of Natural History on Madison Drive NW. There, they were bolted in place.

A time capsule containing mementos was placed in one of the statues.

The installation was the culmination of the museum’s recent effort to reassociate with the iconic animals,

Smithsonian brings bison back to the National Mall

Sculptor Gary Staab, along with a construction crew, works to install two of his bison statues at the Smithsonian Natural History Museum.

which were first brought to the Smithsonian more than a century ago, and later were the first animals in what became the institution’s National Zoo.

The project is also a salute to the nation’s 250th birthday this year, the museum said.

The larger-than-life pieces — one depicting a male bison, the other a female and her calf — were gifts of Wyoming philanthropist, western art collector and longtime Smithsonian supporter Naoma Tate and her family. The cost was not disclosed.

The American bison, once slaughtered almost to extinction, was named the national mammal in 2016, and has long been a symbol of the United States. (Bison, which once numbered between 30 and 60 million across North America, were reduced by

SEE BISON ON A20



KIRSTEN LUCE/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

A bitter development

Maple syrup is the lifeblood of Highland County, Virginia, but climate change — with hot summers and less predictable winters — is wreaking havoc on the industry. **Story, B13**

ROBERT S. MUELLER III 1944-2026

Bastion of calm amid political storms

Former FBI director, special prosecutor spent 40 years in law enforcement

BY MARC FISHER

Robert S. Mueller III, a career prosecutor who became a central figure in two searing national traumas, first as FBI director in the aftermath of the 9/11 terrorist attacks and later as special counsel investigating ties between President Donald Trump’s campaign and Russia, died Friday. He was 81.

Mr. Mueller’s family confirmed his death in a statement Saturday to the Associated Press. Mr. Mueller had been diagnosed with Parkinson’s disease in 2021, according to a statement his family shared with the New York Times last year.

During more than four decades in law enforcement — as line prosecutor, U.S. attorney and FBI chief — Mr. Mueller developed a reputation as a stickler for detail who savored methodical investigation and nearly always got his man. Some colleagues privately spoke of the decorated Marine veteran as “Bobby Three Sticks,” referring to his patrician pedigree and the three-fingered Boy Scout salute.



MELINA MARA/THE WASHINGTON POST

Robert S. Mueller III led the FBI after 9/11 and later investigated Russia’s connection to Donald Trump’s ‘16 presidential campaign.

Mr. Mueller was confirmed as FBI director by a 98-0 Senate vote and reported for duty on Sept. 4, 2001 — one week before the al-Qaeda assaults on the World Trade Center and the Pentagon that would define his tenure. Over the next 12 years, he

became the longest-serving leader of the FBI since J. Edgar Hoover, and he guided the bureau under Presidents George W. Bush and Barack Obama.

SEE MUELLER ON A6

Trump reacts to Mueller’s death: “Good, I’m glad he’s dead.” **A7**

THE WORLD

Russian ship could test the effective U.S. oil blockade of Cuba. **A8**

SPORTS

U-Va. women keep March Madness run going, join men in round of 32. **B1**



BUSINESS

Thousands swooned over a MAGA dream girl. She’s made with AI. **B7**

METRO

Soaring utility bills are injecting acrimony into D.C.’s mayoral race. **B13**



ARTS & STYLE

Meet the lawyer taking on President Donald Trump’s executive orders.

TRAVEL

A Norwegian ferry cruise offers unique views — and lots of king crab.

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